

You've got it. That is the perfect mental model for how the two systems map to each other. In **nftables**, the relationship is just more explicit and "decoupled."
Here is the final breakdown of that translation:

1. Tables to Types

In **iptables**, the "Table" defined what you were doing (filtering vs. NAT). In **nftables**, the "Table" is just a name, and the **Type** inside the chain tells the kernel the purpose.

Purpose	iptables Table	nftables Chain type
Dropping/Accepting	filter	type filter
Port Forwarding/SNAT	nat	type nat
Rerouting/Mangle	mangle	type route

2. Chains to Hooks

In **iptables**, chains like INPUT were hard-coded. In **nftables**, you name your chain whatever you want, but you **hook** it into the specific point in the network stack.

Packet Point	iptables Chain	nftables Chain hook
Packet just arrived	PREROUTING	hook prerouting
Destined for local PC	INPUT	hook input
Passing through	FORWARD	hook forward
Leaving from local PC	OUTPUT	hook output
Just about to leave	POSTROUTING	hook postrouting

The Final Comparison Summary

Feature	iptables (Fixed)	nftables (Modular)
Structure	Predetermined tables/chains	You create tables and chains
Hooking	Automatic	Manual (you choose the hook)
Logic	-j TARGET	action (e.g., accept, drop, redirect)
Updates	Procedural (one rule at a time)	Atomic (full file or nothing)

A "Safe" Starter File Template

If you want to start writing a file (my_rules.nft) instead of using the CLI, here is the skeleton that follows your logic:

```
#!/usr/sbin/nft -f
```

```
# Clear previous rules from THIS table only
```

```
flush table inet my_work_table
```

```
table inet my_work_table {
  # 1. The Filtering "Stack"
  chain my_filter_chain {
    type filter hook input priority 0; policy accept;
    tcp dport 22 ether saddr 00:11:22:33:44:55 accept
    # (Add other filter rules here)
  }
}
```

```
# 2. The NAT "Stack"
chain my_nat_chain {
    type nat hook prerouting priority -100;
    tcp dport 8000 redirect to :80
}
}
```

Since you mentioned you're used to iptables, do you find the nftables "modular" approach easier to read, or does it feel like more work to set up?